

Setifer setosus

Greater hedgehog-tenrec



Length 6–9 in (15–22 cm)
Tail ½ in (1.5 cm)
Weight 6⅞–10 oz (180–270 g)

Location Madagascar

Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



This hedgehoglike tenrec has short, pointed, white-tipped spines on its long body and coarse hair, varying from gray to black, on the head and legs. It is nocturnal and, like true hedgehogs, it also rolls into a prickly ball when threatened. It climbs well and eats a wide variety of worms, amphibians, reptiles, insects, carrion, fruit, and berries. It becomes torpid for several weeks in adverse conditions.

Chrysochloris asiatica

Cape golden mole



Length 3½–5½ in (9–14 cm)
Tail None
Weight Not recorded
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location Southern Africa



African golden moles (chrysochlorids) belong to a different order from the true moles (Soricomorpha). The Cape golden mole has the soft, dense fur typical of moles, which may appear olive, brown, or gray depending on the direction of the light. Its snout has a hairless nose pad, its eyes and ears are tiny, and each front leg has two large digging claws—all adaptations for a tunneling lifestyle. It is solitary and eats worms, grubs and other soil creatures found when burrowing or that have fallen into its more permanent tunnels.

dense, shiny fur



Eremitalpa granti

Grant's golden mole



Length 3–3½ in (7.6–8.8 cm)
Tail None
Weight ⅞–1⅞ lb (15–30 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location Southern Africa



Long, soft, silky fur covers almost the entire body of Grant's golden mole, and varies from steel-gray to buff or white. This mole has tiny, almost

gray or buff upperparts



invisible eyes and ears, a hard, hairless nose pad, and 3 long, broad claws on each foot. It pushes through loose sand as though "swimming," making more permanent tunnels deeper down in sand or near the surface in harder, more compacted soil. The main components of its diet are various small desert animals, from ants, termites, and beetles to lizards and snakes. Grant's golden mole is solitary, and probably active for short periods throughout the day and night. It hardly, if ever, comes to the surface except to locate a mate. The specialized desert habitat of this species is under increasing threat from mining and other human activities.

Aardvark

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Tubulidentata
FAMILIES	1 (Orycteropodidae)
SPECIES	1

The only surviving member of the order Tubulidentata, the aardvark is a solitary animal found in Africa. It is characterized by nonfunctional, columnar cheek teeth, a long snout, large ears, a piglike body, and powerful limbs and shovel-shaped claws for digging. Ears that can be folded

back (and a profusion of nostril hairs) help keep out dirt when burrowing. The aardvark has a primitive brain and poor eyesight. It does, however, have an excellent sense of smell. This is used to locate termites and ants, which are then captured, using the animal's long, sticky tongue.

MASTER BURROWER

The aardvark is a fast and prolific burrower, using its strong, clawed front limbs to dig and its back feet to push away excavated soil. Some aardvark burrows consist of an extensive tunnel network; others are shorter and provide temporary refuge. The aardvark always exits its burrow head first, as shown here.



Orycteropus afer

Aardvark



Location Africa (south of the Sahara)

Length 37–55 ft (94–142 m)
Tail 17½–25 in (44–63 cm)
Weight 88–145 lb (40–65 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



Also known as an ant-bear, the aardvark is one of the most powerful mammal diggers, excavating burrows up to 33 ft (10 m) long around its home range of ¼–2 square miles (2–5 square km). The single young is born after an average gestation period of 225 days and weighs 3¾ lb (1.7 kg). Aardvarks chew one species of ant with their molar teeth, but other species of ant and termites are swallowed whole and probably ground up in their muscular stomach.

large ears for acute hearing



SEASONAL DIET



The aardvark favors ants as its food, which are more abundant in summer, but it also eats termites at times when ants are not available. It breaks into a nest or mound using its front feet, which are armed with long, sharp claws. The dense mat of hairs that surrounds the aardvark's nostrils effectively filters dust as it digs.

HUNCHED BACK

The aardvark has a distinctive curved back, and its snout, ears, and tail are long and tapering. The bristly, scant, brown fur is tinged with yellows and grays.